

Landscape Architecture OnSite | Land van Chabot

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Introduction

Henk Chabot, the polder and the sky

In the days of the painter Henk Chabot (1894-1949), the polders of Rotterdam were still expansive, with an omnipresent horizon, and big skies. The oeuvre Chabot is associated with angular, realistic expressionism of many layers of paint in hard colours, heavily emphasized skies over poor countryside, and monumental portraits of refugees and farmers. For 15 years he lived and worked in a studio at the river Rotte, from where he looked out over the polders and depicted them extensively.

Interstitial space in the metropolitan landscape

In the contemporary metropolitan landscape of Rotterdam, the open landscape spaces that used to surround the city have been reduced to fragments in a hybrid field. Only a relic of the farmland where Chabot lived has remained: an interstice between motorways, recreation parks and suburbs, which seemed to be overlooked in the frenzy of urban planning processes.

Flowscape: Rotte & big infra

The reason this interstice still exists is that it has been a reservation for a future motorway for the last 30 years, and in the not-so-distant future here will be the tunnel entrance for the new A16 motorway. The infrastructure is increasingly developing into an independent system with its accessory functions and buildings, creating its own physical environment with a scale and significance that does not seem to fit in with the old landscape. The Rotte River that used to be the spine of the polder landscape is now a heavily used recreational artery, aiming to incorporate the Land van Chabot as a recreational attraction.

Borrowed boundary

As a left-over space the terrain seems non-descript. However, it does have the implicit characteristics of a ‘landscape theatre’: introducing the processes and the scale of landscape as self-evident elements of the city and heralding the open polder landscape twenty minutes away. It borrows its physical boundaries from the Rotte river dike, the *heemtuin* [botanical garden] adjacent to the Ommoord apartment blocks, the access road to Ommoord, the industrial estate and residential area in Terbregge. Such a “borrowed boundary” can be seen as a defining trait of the landscape theatre. The open space that is defined by this borrowed boundary and the central point of the tunnel entrance, is a secluded, self-contained place, removed in time and space, insulated against the every-day reality and aside from the public realm of streets, squares, and parks, from the hustle and bustle of urban life: a place ‘outside’.

Metropolitan garden

The tunnel project might mean the end of this remnant of open space, ór it could be the moment when a sensitive design intervention can expose the hidden qualities of this meadow, outside the main narrative of recreation and urban functionality. How can this interstitial space be transformed into a generous space, introducing the open sky in the metropolitan landscape without losing its qualities of being outside, indeterminacy and openness? How can the clash of polder landscape, open skies, suburban housing, ecological niches, informal human practices, and infrastructure, be celebrated?

Landscape theatre

Chabot painted what he saw, painted the meeting of land and sky. Introducing the open space of the landscape theatre in the Rotterdam metropolitan landscape means including the horizon, the space of the sky. The horizon is different when viewed in movement than viewed from a standstill, different when viewed from the Rotte than when viewed from the dike, from the house where Chabot lived and worked, or from the polder floor. How can the treatment of the view be the inspiration for the design of this metropolitan garden?

Expected outcomes

- Exhibition of 'situational encounters'
- Sketch Design Land of Chabot in its context
- Built intervention
- Book

Methodology

Inventive analysis and minimal intervention.

Parallel strands of

- situational encounters: perceptual, thematic, and participatory analysis
- theory building: place
- concept design
- object design and building

You will work in a dynamic and fluid group working process, in which continuous exchange between varying groups will eventually lead to one final result. At the start you will work in small groups. Each group develops an initial *concept* and performs, represents and present different forms of *eye level analysis*. Additionally, each group will perform 1 of the 3 *thematic analyses*.

Halfway the project we will make different groups. Each of these group will be responsible for organizing a different part of the final work: 1) concept development, 2) construction of OnSite intervention, 3) exhibition. All the others will help with the work, with this one group in the lead.

Scales

Green structure – role in green structure (scenography, recreation, ecology, etc.)	- understanding
Land of Chabot	- concept
Object (entrance, viewing object, etc.)	- construction

1. Eye level perceptual analysis (all)

1. walking
2. cycling
3. boating
4. playing
5. below and above (tunnel and flat)
6. painting

2. Thematic analysis (1 group each)

Group 1	outside -	(borrowed) boundaries
Group 2	inside -	(micro) relief, soil and water
Group 3	relations -	(traces of) human and non-human practices and uses

3. Theory (all)

The design location is a leftover, interstitial space. Yet, it has specific qualities that might define it as a place. What does 'place' mean? How can design bring the hidden qualities to the surface?

In collaboration with the students of EcoCampus you will each read a book that addresses the notion of place from a different angle, present and discuss it with the other groups.

4. Site concept

Concept development (all groups) | Presentation and selection | Design elaboration of one proposal (1 group)

In small groups you will develop 3 different concepts. After presentation, together (students, inhabitants, tutors) we will select one (and implement the good ideas of the others). After the presentation we will regroup, again in 3 (different) groups. One of the groups has the task to elaborate the selected concept into 1 final concept.

5. Temporary object on site

Concept development (all groups)

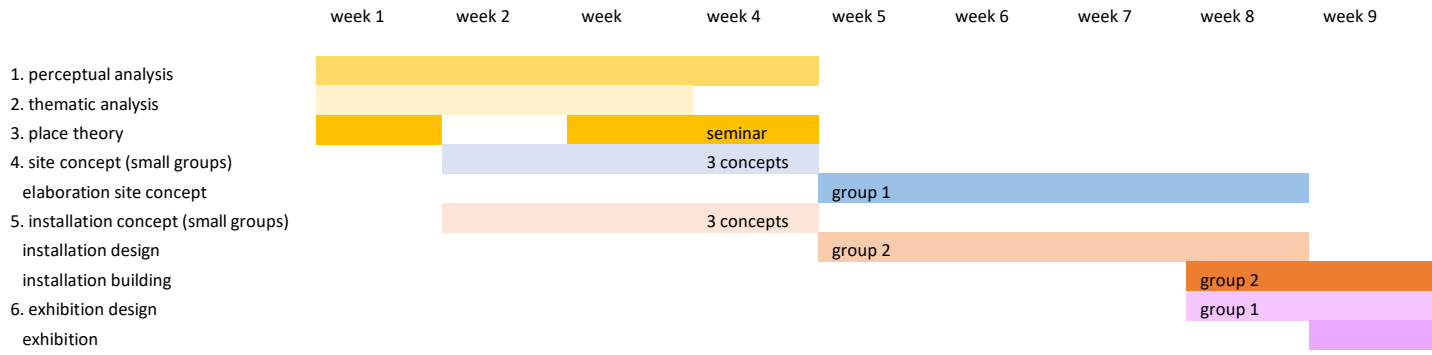
Presentation and selection

Design elaboration of one proposal (1 group)

Building

6. Exhibition

Exhibition design and building: Situational encounters, concept/design. (1 group)



7. Book

The site readings (situational encounters), elaborated design and built work will be brough together in a book.

Programme

24 April	9:30	**Introduction**	studio
	14:00	**Seminar 1. Designerly ways of looking**	room t.b.d.
	14:00	Ruud Reutelingsperger	Art as a form of reflection (way of looking, not the design)
	15:00	Steffen Nijhuis	Eye level perspective
	16:00	Lotte Oppenhuis	Poetic management

26 April	9:30	**Walking**	on site



start at Metro Binnenhof, Rotterdam

	14:00	**Seminar 2. Context**	Chabotmuseum

Museumpark 32 (Metro Eendrachtsplein)

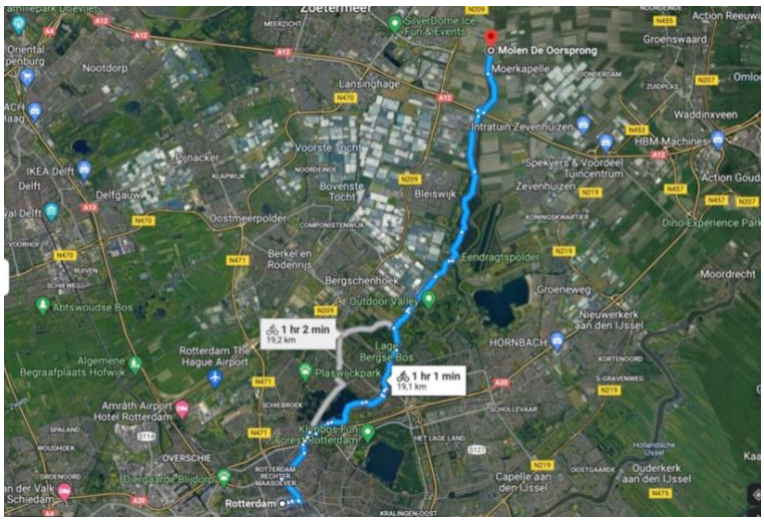
14:00	Saskia de Wit	Metropolitan landscapes and interstitial spaces
15:00	Carla Hendriks	Henk Chabot
16:00	Yolanda Boekhoudt/Martin Looije	Context and policy (recreatieschap Rottemeren / A16)

May 1	14:00	**Tutoring in groups**	studio

Working On Site

May 2	10:00	thematic analysis (small group)
	13:00	Perceptual analysis: above & below

May 3	9:30	Perceptual analysis: cycling	on site



Starting point Rotterdam CS. Cycling to the source of the Rotte.

visit surrounding green spaces: Wijktuin Ommoord, Ommoordse Veld, Lage Bergsche Bos…

	14:00	thematic analysis (small group)	
May 4	10:00	Thematic analysis (small group)	on site
	14:00	Perceptual analysis: painting	
May 8	10:00	Tutoring in groups	studio
May 10	14:00	Perceptual analysis: boating	on site
May 15	10:00-12:30	<u>Seminar 3. Place</u>	studio
		Presentation and discussion	
	14:00	Tutoring in groups	studio
May 17	10:00	Presentation and selection concepts	on site
June 19-22		<u>Building intervention and exhibition</u>	
June 23		<u>Presentation</u>	

Literature

Place

- Augé, Marc. 1995. *Non-places: an introduction to super-modernity*, translated by John Howe. Verso.
- Casey, Edward S. 1998. *The fate of place; a philosophical history*. University of California Press.
- Hayden, Dolores. 1995.*The Power of Place: Urban landscapes as Public History*. The MIT Press.
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- Walter, Eugene Victor. 1988. *Placeways: A Theory of the Human Environment*. University of North Carolina Press.
- Wit, S.I. de & Piccinini, D. (2014). *What makes a place? A landscape architectural story about place.* (unpublished).

(Land of) Chabot

- Wit, Saskia de & Dekker, André. 2020. 'Land of Chabot. A highway landscape as a monument to a painter,' in *SPOOL Landscape Metropolis #6. The Garden in the Landscape Metropolis.*
- Palmboom, Frits. *Rotterdam Verstedelijkt Landschap*.
- Vollemans, K. & Akker, j. van den. *Chabot – The moon and the eye*. 1001 Uitgeverij, 1991.

Interstitial spaces

- Barron, Patrick & Mariani, Manuela (eds.) 2014. *Terrain Vague; Interstices at the Edge of the Pale*. Routledge.